

Cooking With HTML 5

What's new, and what can you do with it?

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As users, it doesn't really matter to us how the sites we visit are built. Overused divs, tables for layout – who cares, as long as the sites look and work fine?

As developers, though, it all matters. And as the web becomes increasingly aware of semantics – the context of content – it also matters that we build pages that the search engines understand. And that's why there's HTML 5.

HTML 5 gets a lot of press for one feature alone: the `<video>` tag, which lets you embed Ogg video into pages, without needing plugins like Flash or Silverlight. That tag, however, is just part of a much bigger design – to make the tags indicative of what the pages contain.

Tagged right

Most web pages you'll visit have a layout that looks something like this:

```
<body>
<div id="header">
<!--your page header and logo go here-->
<div id="nav">
<!--your navigation links go here-->
</div>
</div>
<div id="content-area">
<div class="article">
<h2>This is a heading</h2>
<p>This is some text.</p>
</div>
<div class="article">
<h2>This is another heading</h2>
<p>This is some more text.</p>
</div>
</div>
<div id="sidebar">
<!--your sidebar information goes here-->
</div>
<div id="footer">
<!--your copyright and contact information goes here-->
</div>
</body>
```

Pretty standard stuff, that. The problem, however, is that divs don't really mean anything. They tell the browser that they're distinct areas of the document with "stuff" inside them, but that's it. With HTML 5, however, we get structural elements that

actually tell us what's inside:

The `<header>` element to put all introductory information, like your logo, a brief description of the page, and so on. You can also use these as content headers, which can contain the title.

The `<nav>` element, to put your primary navigation links in.

The `<section>` element, to segregate your content into chapters, categories, or anything similar.

The `<article>` element, where you can stick your primary content.

The `<aside>` element, where you can put stuff that's tangentially related to the content around the aside element, and which could be considered separate from that content, according to the W3C. This means sidebars, pull-quotes, and other such content that isn't part of the main flow.

Finally, the `<footer>` element, where you can put copyright notices, contact details, and so on. Like `<header>`, you can also use this for article footers – date published, number of comments, and so on.

As you can see, the new tags make much more sense – both when you're creating a page, and if you have to edit a page someone else created.

Putting it together

Now that we've got new tags to work with, we can set about rebuilding our page, starting with the easiest bits. The header is simple enough:

```
<header class="mainhead">
<h1>This is the page header</h1>
<nav>
<ul>
<li><a href="somewhere.
htm">Navigation 1</a></li>
<li><a href="somewhere.
htm">Navigation 2</a></li>
<li><a href="somewhere.
htm">Navigation 3</a></li>
</ul>
</nav>
</header>
```

It's not absolutely essential to have the navigation links within the header, but since they are an "introduction" to what's on your site, it makes sense to put them there.

The other simple element is the aside:

```
<aside>
<ul>
<li><!--a calendar widget--></li>
<li><!--an archive widget--></li>
</ul>
```

```
</aside>
```

This is a very WordPress-like sidebar, with widgets in an unordered list. You can use divs too, if you like.

There's also the sections:

```
<section id="articlesnippets">
<article class="snippet">
<!--article preview goes here-->
</article>
</section>
```

...and so on. If you use the HTML 5 elements the way you would divs, you're on the right track.

Articles of interest

Apart from the obvious `<article>` element, HTML 5 gives us several other elements to add richness to content. The first is `<hgroup>`, which lets us group headings (for the benefit of search engines, which would see ungrouped headings as separate content items):

```
<article class="full">
<header class="article-header">
<hgroup>
<h1>This is the main heading</h1>
<h2>This is the subheading</h2>
<h3>Author</h3>
</hgroup>
</header>
<!--article content goes here-->
</article>
```

If you have images within the content, you can use the `<figure>` element to show it – adding more significance to its purpose:

```
<figure id="figure-1">
<legend>This becomes the figure's caption</legend>

</figure>
```

This doesn't have to be limited to images – just replace the `<img>` with `<audio>` or `<video>`, and you've got yourself captioned audio or video.

There are a bunch of little additions for your content, too – use the `<mark>` tag (or `<m>`; the spec is still undecided on which) to highlight text that you think is significant (you can use CSS to decide how that looks):

```
<p>This was a triumph. I'm making a note here: <mark>HUGE SUCCESS</mark>.</p>
```

You can also mark off time (`<time>`), or other units (`<meter>`):

```
<p>I made <meter>Rs. 300</meter> at <time>10:15 AM on August 5</time>.
```

But this is just the boring, utilitarian part.